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Ancestral Worship among Hindus A Case Study of Select Villages from Jhajjar District in Haryana

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Abstract Ancestral worship or *Pitr Puja* is a common ritual among all religions. Hindus gave much respect to their dead ancestors by giving special sixteen-day *Shraaddh* rites in the month of *Ashwin* (Sept-Oct). In this paper, various forms of rituals practised by Hindus of selected caste villages from Haryana state are explored. An extensive door-to-door (Household-HH) field survey was conducted in five villages in the Jhajjar district of Haryana during 2020-2021. Selected caste villagers' primary census survey was carried out by gathering data from 980 Households (HH). The study aimed to explore and understand the importance of ancestors in the day-to-day life of a common Hindu and the reasons behind it. Numerous interviews with different castes people find out the reasons behind the veneration of ancestors. Qualitative data was synthesized with the help of QDA (Minor Lite) software. The largest numbers of *PitrMadhis* were built by the Sainis, followed by Ahirs, Jats, Brahmans and SCs. Various built forms of *Madhis* were the expressions of the economic condition of the household. Rituals for ancestral worship practised among different caste people were based on participative observation. It can be concluded that ancestral worship is an obligation for every sanctimonious Hindu. Feeding the dead (ancestors) is an essential sacred observance among Hindus. Imprints of ancestors are visible in the happy and sad moments of a Hindu household.

Keywords Hindu, Rituals, Caste, Worship, Ancestor, Faith.

Introduction According to Merriam-Webster Dictionary, an ancestor is "one from whom a person is descended; this includes one's parents, grandparents, or great-grandparents." In the Indian scriptures, the Rig Veda asserts that ancestors are deliberated as semi-divine beings (demigods). The main difference between the divine god and ancestors is that the latter does not possess the power to punish sinners, while the gods have it. Hence, the ancestors store valuable gifts and can dole out curses (Sayers, 2013). "Anthropologists studying traditional kinship-based cultures have frequently, and perhaps universally, encountered the claim that dead ancestors (deceased progenitors) can still influence, and or be influenced by, their living descendants" (Clark & Palmer, 2016, p. 1). In the Indian context, the discourse on domestic ritual reflects on the inherited textualised version of ancestor worship and the broader untextualised tradition, gradually integrating them into a single ritual cycle of ancestral rites known as the *Shraaddh*-rite. This new tradition of ancestral rites differs in scale, its principal human actors, and the manner of ritual interaction. It becomes the paradigm for ancestral veneration for the subsequent tradition. "The authors of the Dharmasutras and the Dharmasastras accept the *Shraaddh*-rite as the paradigmatic rite of ancestor veneration. Gradually, it becomes a central part of their prescription for proper religious life" (Sayers, 2013, p. 21). Perhaps the Hindus have a strong sense of transmitting the value of respect to their elders, whether alive or dead. In all ages humans have paid respect to their elders, whether alive or dead. In the fast changing social and economic life, people still have enough space for their forefathers. Ancestor worship is a universal practice as each society regards its forefathers. In Hindu society, ancestor worshipping has two aspects: *Shraaddhs* practised in the month of *Ashwin (Sept-Oct.)* and making a *Chhatri* or *Madhi* in the name of family ancestors for daily and occasional rituals. The main idea behind ancestor worship is to earn heavenly merit by enabling the dead to rejoin their present generation. Ibbetson (1919, Vol-1, p. 199) writes: "For another reason, in a village in Gurgaon, the spirit of young men who died childless, discontented, and unwilling to leave their home is also supposed to haunt the family or village. Worship of the dead is done in two forms- the sainted dead (*Pitr*) and the malevolent dead (sonless dead)" (Ibbetson, 1919, Vol-1, p. 199).In order to pacify or counter *Pitr*, a stone or set of three or five bricks is commonly placed outside the home or in fields called *PitrMadhi*. The faith of Hindus in their ancestors is as old as the religion itself. Some individual household may not have *Madhi*, but within a *Kunba* (a group of families belonging to a single forefather), one will find some *PitrMadhis*. After that,

other ancestral shrines built are known as *PitrMadhis.* These are personal matters of a particular household or a *Kunba*. These rituals are practiced from local to Pan-Indian scale. *Pinddaan* for ancestors is very common among Hindus at various sacred places like Kurukshetra, Bodh Gaya and Haridwar etc. Kurukshetra, in Haryana is a well-known centre of faith enumerated in Mahabharta, various *Puranas,* and non-Hindu sources like *Aain-e-Akbari* (Bhardwaj, 1973). The place is auspicious for *PindDaan* during *Shraaddhs*. On the day of *Amavasya*, Hindus of the north-western region of the country visit *Braham Sarovar* for peace of their ancestral souls and sacred bathing.

Aim of study The present paper aims to explore the various forms of ancestral worship practices prevalent among present-day Hindus of various castes. It was a quest to understand the reasons behind ancestral worship in the select villages, to know the mode of worshipping and the occasions on which the dead persons of a family are remembered.

Review of Literature Shastri (1963) starts with the *Brahmanas* text mentioning the beliefs of ancestral rebirth. The dead after funerals get their place as *Pitrs*. Their *Pinddan* is performed at Gaya. He establishes that *Pitr Yajna* and *Pind Pitr Yajna* are the Vedic forms of ancestor worship. Their local expression is found in the form of *PitrMedhas*, where they are worshipped on daily or occasional functions. During *Shraaddhs* a full fortnight is devoted to ancestors with ritualistic veneration. Bhattacharya (1971) in his Ph.D thesis studied the Concept of *Shraaddha* in Post-Vedic Hinduism in detail involving the ritual steps involved and compared it to Vedic rituals. Das (1982) in her book has remarked about caste differences and ritual differentiation in Hindus. Caste differences exist even in close proximity and are evident in the ritual processions. Jamison (1991) talks about rituals inherited from the older tradition that composed the *Rig Veda* as "the ideally portable religion" in that the liturgy is memorized by those who enact it and the materials used in the ritual are implements used in everyday life or created for that particular instance, such as the ritual space and the fire. Specific places are not recognized as sacred; rather the ritual space in which the ritual will occur is created through a meticulous demarcation of sacred space (ancestral). McAnany (1995) details this relationship, focusing on connections between agricultural practice and ancestor veneration from pre-Columbian to colonial times in the Mayan area (Maya Civilisation). He notes that land rights, particularly agricultural lands, were inherited from ancestors. Thus, ancestors, though deceased remained a significant part of society. Although case material is drawn from the Maya region, it offers a good example of veneration of ancestors. Prasad (1997) remarks on the importance of sixteen *Samskaras* encompassing the life of a Hindu, of which the last rites are performed by their sons or grandsons. *Puranas* and *Dharmasastras* praised the role of a son in the death rites of a devout Hindu. His work deals in detail with the *Shraaddh* rites and justifies the popular Hindu belief that dead ancestors are part and parcel of the Hindu family and hence ancestor worship is requisite for one's prosperity. It is necessary for the continuity of one's race as believed from the Rigvedic period. Ghosh (2002) portrayed the Hindu view of life in its totality based on his wider review of more than 500 ancient texts. He wrote about the cult of immortality, karma, transmigration of souls, ancestral worship image worshipping. Sayers (2013) in his masterpiece (Feeding the Dead) reveals the ancestral rites of Hindus from the early Vedic period. He explains in detail the solemn ancestral rights and domestic rice ball sacrifice to the ancestors in detail. *Shraaddh* rites are dealt at length even traced from the Buddhist literature in addition to Puranas and Vedas. Sayers (2015) sees the association of Hinduism with reincarnation as well-known. This connection obscures a long tradition of ancestor worship. The ritual texts of the Vedic and later Hindu traditions describe in detail the procedure for several forms of ancestral rites. This paper outlines the development of the theological discourse on ancestor worship from its earliest expression to the formation of Classical Hinduism early in the Common Era and highlights the underlying theological, social, and practical concerns that shaped that discourse. Kumar and Cincala (2021), describe that faith, fear, and force are the three main factors influencing ancestral worship in Hindus. They explained these factors with case studies based on interviews at different places in India. All three factors have their own effects stimulating different emotions regarding their ancestors. People wish to be happy and prosperous and hence they tend to venerate their ancestors. This review of literature provides a niche for a case from a local place concerned with the rituals and rites observed while venerating the ancestors. Hence the study was conducted to fill the gap in literature.

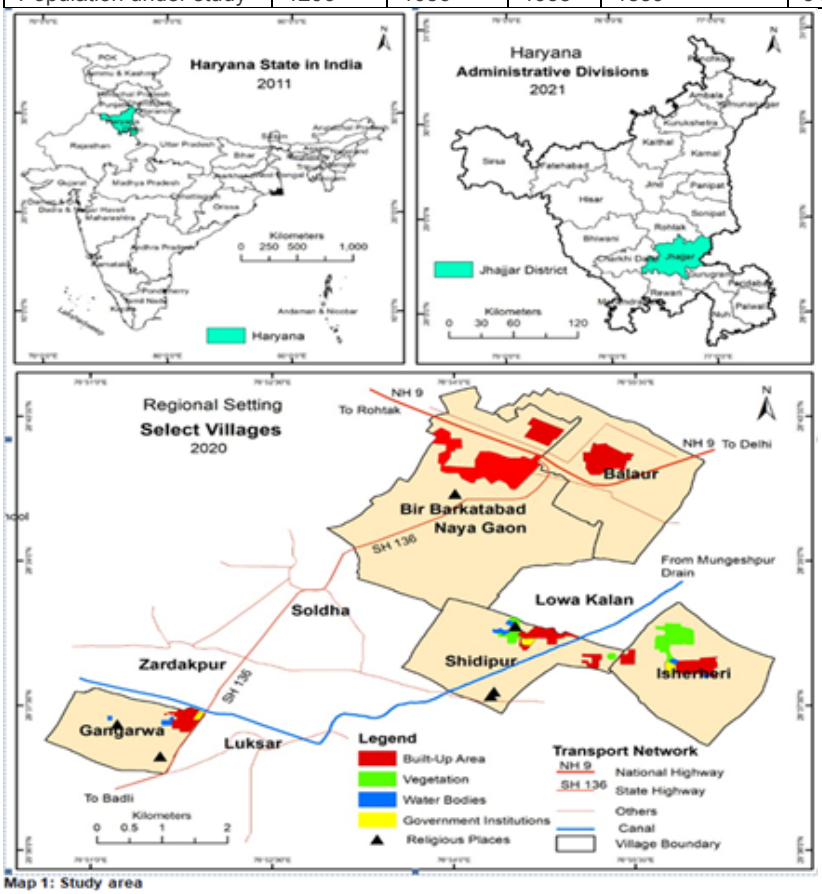
Methodology The paper rests on a mixed qualitative and quantitative methodology. Fieldwork entries were filled from each selected caste household from the five selected caste villages from Jhajjar district of the state of Haryana. The purposively selected villages had a majority or larger share (> 25 per cent) of one caste household (HH). The village Balaur was surveyed for 295 HH of Ahirs (Yadav), Isherheri for 214 HH of Jats, Shidipur for 177 HH of Brahmans, Naya Gaon for 234 HH of Sainis, and Gangarwa was surveyed for 60 HH of SC (Chamar). This selection aimed to know the inter-caste differences among Hindus for analyzing differences in beliefs and causes of ancestral worship. Extensive fieldwork was carried out to gather HH-level primary data encompassing 980 HH in five villages in the year 2020-21. The primary aim was to explore various forms of ancestor worship. Numerous interviews regarding the built-up expressions of ancestral shrines were completed. The rituals and rites performed by different caste householders were qualitatively synthesized with the help of QDA (Minor Lite) software.

Result and Discussion **Location and Demography of the Study Villages:** Five villages were purposively selected from Jhajjar district of Haryana state. Four villages were selected from Bahadurgarh *Tehsil* and one from Badli *Tehsil* (Map 1).

These five caste villages had 980 HH of selected single majority caste, encompassing a total population of 6437 persons (Table 1).

Table 1. Study villages- the selected caste, number of HH and population (selected from Jhajjar district, Haryana).

Name of Village	Isherheri	Shidipur	Balaur	Naya Gaon (Bir Barkatabad)	Gangarwa	Total
Caste of Respondents	Jat	Brahman	Ahir	Saini	Chamar	05
No. of Households (HH)	214	177	295	234	60	980
Population under study	1206	1086	1958	1839	348	6437



Map 1: Study area

Broad Categories of Ancestor Veneration: Broadly two forms of ancestral worship practices were ubiquitous among all select caste people- the veneration in the form of *PitrMadhis* and *Shraaddh* rites. Both are discussed at length in the text.

***Pitr Madhis* in the study villages: Origin, Form, and Beliefs**

At **Isherheri**, one man who died in 1981 was a well-known natural healer known as *Hakim/Vaid* Arjan Singh. As he was a man of exceptional natural understanding of human ailments, the family decided to make his *Madhi* in their fields where the *Vaid* used to live in a hut. In 2009 the family reconstructed the *Madhi* and transposed a stone image of their grandfather. In another case, a family had a man who died without children. Later, the family had problems with animals, men-women of the HH, and loss in agriculture. Then on the advice of a *syana/pandit* (wise-man), they constructed a small shrine of *PitrMadhi* in their field, and the family then felt relief from all the problems they had faced in the past. A few *PitrMadhis* from the village are shown in Fig. 1

Fig. 3: *PitrMadhi* and *Chattri* at Balaur

Fig. 1: Various built types of *PitrMadhi* belonging to different *Kunbaat* village Isherheri

Fig. 2: *PitrMadhis* at village Shidipur

At **Shidipur** and **Balaur**, several narratives lie behind the construction of *PitrMadhis* (Figures 2 & 3). There are two types of such shrines existing in these villages. One is *Chhatri* (the place mainly in the fields of the dead where the dead person was cremated) and *Madhi* (the place for revering the ancestor). Both of these structures are visited by the concerned family on specific occasions of *Pitr* worship. In addition, some families have *PitrMadhi* within their premises/front of the house or in their plots/fields. At **Naya Gaon (BB)**, more significant numbers of *PitrMadhis* existed (Fig. 4). A man in this village explained another story behind the construction of *PitrMadhi*. According to him, one of his uncles died at a younger age. His mother and aunty usually saw him as *Pitr* in their dreams. One time both these ladies saw him saying that this time a male baby would be born in the family. The following year it happened, and the family made a *PitrMadhi* of the deceased young man in their field. Almost every shrine has its narrative in each village.

Fig. 4: *PitrMadhi* at village Naya Gaon (BB)

At **Gangarwa**, only a few HH has *PittrMadhi*. A *Kunba* of Dhaniya *gotra* has the *Madhi* of one man Mastan, a Mata Nagarkot (Himachal Pradesh) devotee. As he was unmarried, so after his death, a *PitrMadhi* was constructed by the people of his *Kunba* (Fig. 5). Today all the HH of this *gotra* visit his shrine.

Fig. 5: *PitrMadhi* of Mastan Bhagat at village Gangarwa

Rituals and Practices at *PitrMadhis*

The highest numbers of HH having *PitrMadhi* are at Naya Gaon, where most Saini HH constructed and revere their ancestors. At Balaur (Ahirs), Isherheri (Jats), and Shidipur (Brahmans), more than one-half of HH have *PitrMadhis* (Table 2). The slightest reverence of *Pitrs* in the form of *PitrMadhis* was found among Chamars of Gangarwa, where about one-fourth of HH have *Madhi*s.

Table 2: Visiting *PitrMadhis*, a local sacred place in the study villages

Note: Figures in parentheses indicate the percentage; BB- Bir Barkatabad,
Source: Primary Survey, 2020-21

The most significant number of HH in the study area have ancestral shrines in their fields or plots, while fewer are built at home also. Some perform the bathing ritual and lit lamps and offer food at first to their ancestors with varying frequencies ranging from daily, weekly, fortnightly, and monthly to annual festivities and special family functions like marriages and childbirth (Table 2). On special occasions, the *Pitrs* are fed before the household members eat their meals. On the morning of each month's *Amavasya*, a family member offers fresh food, mainly sweetened rice boiled in milk (*Kheer*), and lights a lamp inside the small shrine. Daily and weekly visits are done by one per cent to fifteen per cent HH in different villages. Many families who visit their fields for agricultural purposes pay due respect to the *Madhi*. Food is offered first at festivals like Holi and Diwali, and a lamp is lit. During *Shraaddhas* (ritual of feeding the dead for sixteen days), specially prepared food is offered at *PitrMadhi*. If a family has any particular function like marriage and birth celebration, they also visit this shrine and seek blessings and well-being for the newcomers in the family. All the HH who keep cows/buffalo also offers first milk at *PitrMadhi* along with *Bhaiyan/Pachvir*. *Chadar* is also offered at the shrine in case of any boon sought from the ancestor is fulfilled.

***Pitr Paksha* or *Shraaddh* or Ancestral Worship**

It seems that ancestral worship is an obligation for every sanctimonious Hindu. Feeding the dead (ancestors) is an essential sacred observance among Hindus. According to Kumar and Cincala (2021), faith, fear, and force are the three main factors influencing ancestral worship in Hindus. First, faith is a belief system in people's minds and souls, both in tangible rituals and intangible gods. So, the faithful Hindus follow the practices instructed by their elders as their responsibility to their ancestors. Second, the force can be the source of ancestral worship which may come from: "(i) force from family, (ii) societal expectations, and (iii) force from spiritual gurus or priests. Third, the force to participate in such worship comes from the desire to advance and prosper in life" (Kumar & Cincala, 2021, p. 166). A young person narrated one example of societal pressure at Isherheri, whose father expired some years ago. His father used to say that whenever he died, there was no need to disperse his in the Ganga River. He thought that after losing a person if the grief-ridden persons visit Garh Ganga, located about 160 kilometres away, it might attract miss happenings. So, he dictated to his children not to perform the ritual of *asthivisarjan*. However, when he died, his sons denied the ritual, but under societal pressure, they had to perform it unwillingly. The third factor is the fear of ancestors.

"The feeling of fear was seen in nearly every qualitative interview. The fear of the dead tormenting them or bringing a curse to the family are some of the primary reasons why Hindus do not intend to upset their ancestors. In fact, over a quarter (28.6%) of surveyed respondents reported that they believe that if they do not carry out the proper ancestral rituals, the ancestors will be angry and will cause bad fortune to befall the family. Several such fear incidences led people to take extreme steps and become involved in occult activities and witchcraft to either protect themselves from the dead or to please them" (Kumar &Cincala, 2021, p. 168).

Due to these three factors, many households in the study villages had constructed ancestral shrines (*PitrMadhi*).

Village Name (No. of HH)/ Frequency to visit *PitrMadhi*	**Isherheri (214 HH)**	**Shidipur (177 HH)**	**Balaur (295 HH)**	**Naya Gaon (BB) (234 HH)**	**Gangarwa (60 HH)**
Daily	31 (14.5)	09 (5.1)	45 (15.3)	30 (12.8)	01 (1.7)
Weekly	05 (2.3)	04 (2.3)	08 (2.7)	24 (10.3)	0
Monthly (Amavasya)	131 (61.2)	98 (55.4)	182 (61.7)	195 (83.3)	16 (26.7)
On festivals (Holi, Diwali etc.)	131 (61.2)	98 (55.4)	182 (61.7)	197 (84.2)	16 (26.7)
On special occasions (marriages, birth, offering first milk of cow/buffalo, during *Shraaddhs*	131 (61.2)	98 (55.4)	182 (61.7)	197 (84.2)	16 (26.7)
Do not have *PitrMadhi*	83 (38.8)	79 (44.6)	113 (38.3)	37 (15.8)	44 (73.3)

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Fig. 6: Various ritualistic observances in the study villages on the day of *Shraaddh*.

This traditional worship practice, known as *Shraaddh*-rites, has a well-defined time in the Hindu lunar calendar. These rites are observed for sixteen days. The first day is the *Purnima* of *Bhadrapada* month, and then from the first day of *Ashwin* (September-October) month (*Prathama* or *Padwa*) until the fifteenth day (*Amavasya* or new moon day). Throughout the study area, *Shraaddh* rites are followed for three generations only. It means if I am the oldest surviving member of my household, then *Shraaddhs* of any deceased in my generation, my parents and grandparents will be observed. *Shraaddh* rites of ancestors of the fourth generation are not observed as they are believed to be part of peaceful and contented souls. However, in almost each study village, one or more common ancestor's *Shraaddh* is observed by the whole *Kunba* as per the wish of the dead. One such example is a lady named Shankho, an unmarried girl. When she died, she asked her *Kunba* to observe her *Shraaddh* rites. She belongs to the eighth-generation ancestor, but still, her rites are observed based on her demand. It is a common consensus among more than 100 households of these three *Kunbas* that it should continue to avoid any unwanted incident or to get her blessings. It was also

narrated by many householders throughout the study area that whatever food was liked by the ancestor when alive, given preferences while observing *Shraaddh*. The most likely food items prepared are *Kheer*, *Halwa*, and rice.

In the simplest ritual observance, the following sequence of events takes place-

1. In the morning, fresh water is brought to prepare food for the ancestor. By 7 or 8 am, food is prepared. Then, the member who had to observe the *Shraaddh* took a bath and prepared for the sacred observance.
2. Some households observe *havan* in the memory of a dead ancestor before *Shraaddh* rites but not for all the *Shraaddhs*.
3. The person designated for the observance is generally a male member. He places the specially prepared sweetened food on half-baked slices of bread (*kachchi roti*). Three or four sets are prepared for the crows, cows, and dogs (Fig 6).
4. (east). Finally, he joins hands and asks the ancestor for constant blessing for the family. The households with *PitrMadhis* built near their premises or in fields visit it first and offer bread and water there.
5. Then, he takes the second bread, moves outside the home, and offers the bread to the cow(s).
6. The third bread is given to the dog, preferably black. In this way, the ritual cycle of *Shraaddh* completes, and the family eats the meals afterwards.
7. Many families send prepared food to the pandit in the village temple.

Differences in *Shraaddh* rituals in the study area

Shraaddh-rites are very simple among **Jats of Isherheri**. They believe that offering food made in freshwater was sufficient for their ancestors. A few families now invite a Brahman living in the village temple on the day of a special *Shraaddh* for the *havan* and offer food to him. The village has only two Brahman families living in the village. These families are not practicing levite work, so they do not accept food offered during *Shraaddhs*. One older man (87 years old) told a different story about ancestral rites. A Brahman named Kundan belonging to Badli (Jhajjar) village used to visit the Jat households on the day of *Amavasya* for food offerings up to the 1960s. Later on, such traditions were abandoned.

Brahmans of Shidipur more strictly observed *Shraaddh*-rites. Being Brahmans, the households who do not practice lavatory work invite those who practice it. Most families prefer to invite their daughter's son (*Dhevta*) or sisters' son (*Bhanja*) during *Shraaddhs*. Hindus consider it highly meritorious to offer food to *Bhanja/Dhevta* during this fortnight.

Among the **Ahirs of Balaur**, generally, a householder invites a *pandit* during the *Shraaddhs* or offers food at the village temple's *pandit***.** However, most families prefer to offer food to him on the day of *Amavasya*, the last day of *pitrpaksha***.**

The **Sainis of Naya Gaon**are their ancestors' greatest worshippers if we look at the number of *PitrMadhis* in their village (84.2 per cent of households)**.** All these households first visit the *Pitr* shrine and offer food and water at the particular place made for the ancestors. Among the **Chamars of Gangarwa**, the *Shraaddh* rites are customarily carried out. All the 39 households of Sambarwal *Gotra* take out the *Shraaddh* of their one common ancestor belonging five generations back, in addition to their current ancestors.

Changes in rituals during *Shraaddhs*

Post-1980-90s, the ritual incorporated some changes. Before that time, no household was allowed to grind grains for sixteen days. Flour was stored in advance for this purpose. Now, this condition is abolished as many find it useless. During this period, no shopping and auspicious work was started, but now the resistance is seen in older people only.

Conclusion

A typical Hindu life is ritualistic amid day-to-day hardships. Ancestral worshipping is an age-old practice among all selected castes. Sixteen special days are attributed to the family's dead ancestors in the form of *Pitr Paksha* or *Shraaddhas*. Usually, the last three generations' dead are fed these days ritualistically. Every household in the select villages observes this ritual. So, it may be summed up that amid the highs and lows of life, a select caste villager or a Hindu generally passes through these rituals daily. They may be happy or sad, but these sacred rituals lie close to their hearts and form an inseparable part of their lives.

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